

The Best Advice I Ever Got

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New York-listed Genpact is a global professional services firm



‘Curiosity and empathy: Essential leadership values’

What was the problem you were grappling with?

Early in my career, I was presented with an opportunity to lead a team of people much older and experienced than me. I knew from the word go that I had to tactfully earn their respect and trust.

Who did you approach for advice and why?

I connected with a few people in leadership positions whom I regarded highly. Since this was new territory for me, I wanted the best advice on how to navigate a challenging situation.

What was the advice you received?

I received some amazing advice. I was told to approach the situation with curiosity and humility, to nurture a cognitively diverse team—which is essential for success. At the centre of this is the ability to ask questions, learn continuously and be empathetic.

How effective was it in resolving the problem?

Had I approached this leadership position with the assumption that I knew everything, I would have learnt nothing, and wouldn't

have been able to embrace the diverse perspectives of my team members. I was self-aware and asked my team to teach me what I didn't know, which was a lot! I was honest and willing to learn.

Over the years I've faltered, learnt, and succeeded enough to believe in three core leadership values that matter the most to me. First, build diverse teams. Second, nurture and build a culture of adaptability. And third, make curiosity, empathy and humility the core of all behaviours. **BT**

—ABHIK SEN

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